INTRODUCTION

GEC 8 – Ethics, deals with morality particularly to the standards of right or wrong that the individual picks up in the community. This course will help the students to develop his moral character and other values necessary as a member of the community. The course will also teach the students to make moral decisions and judgment to enhance their personalities. Also included are the different steps of the development of moral character. The main output of the course is to prepare the students ethical behavior in the workplace.

What is this learning pack all about?

This learning pack is designed for independent study. The different modules deal with the fundamental ethics principles which are essential in understanding moral values and character. It will also provide the students with a very solid foundation of the different types of ethical system. It will compare and contrast various ethical systems in terms of how **good** is defined, and how **right** is defined in terms of the **good.** It will also provide a comparative analysis concerning the different types of moral principles subscribed to by the various ethical systems and it will demonstrate how these types of ethical systems figure in the technique of analyzing moral dilemmas.

To make learning more meaningful and effective, the students are instructed to follow these guidelines:

1. Take time in reading each lesson. Understand what you are reading. From time to time, your teacher will be evaluating you in the form of (online) discussion and other activities in reinforcing learning.
2. At the end of each lesson, a number of activities are prepared to augment your knowledge in Ethics. Carefully follow the instructions provided and be sure to work on the said activities.

MODULE 1. Ethics, Morality and Moral Standards

Objectives:

At the end of the module, the students should be able to:

- ✓ Define ethics and morality;
- ✓ Explain why they have to follow rules;
- ✓ Distinguish the concept of moral standards from non-moral standards and amoral standards;
- ✓ Articulate the differences of ordinary rules from moral rules/standards.

LESSON 1. Ethics Defined

What is Ethics?

The term ethics is derived from the Greek word *ethos*, which originally means custom or character. Broadly construed, ethics is a branch of philosophy that studies the rightness or wrongness of a human action. In particular, this branch of philosophy is concerned with questions of how human persons ought to act, and the search for a definition of a right conduct and the good life. It is for this reason that the attempt to seek the "good" through the aid of reason is the traditional goal of ethicists (Albert, Denise & Peterfreund 1984, p. 1-2).

It must be noted, however, that there is no single, absolute definition of ethics. This is because ethics as a discipline is constantly evolving as a result of a change in socio-cultural and political context. For example, in the Greek tradition, ethics was conceived as relating to the concept of the "good life". Thus, the ethical inquiry during this time was directed toward discovering the nature of happiness. In fact, Aristotle's *Nicomachean Ethics* does not only present a theory of happiness but also provides ways in which happiness is attained. Now, centuries later, a quite different orientation was introduced by the Judeo-Christian tradition. In this ethical tradition, the ideals of righteousness before God and the love of God and neighbor, not the happy or pleasant life, constitute the substance of ethics. Indeed, if we make an effort to reconcile these views, we are faced with the difficult task of defining the relationship between "doing what is right" and "being happy". Again, it is for this reason that we cannot have an absolute definition of ethics. The least that we can do, in my opinion, is to describe the nature and dynamics of ethics based on a specific time and context.

It is also important to note that ethics is not the same with morality, although many philosophers believe that the two terms can be used interchangeably. This is because the former denotes the theory of right action and the greater good, while the latter indicates practice, that is, the rightness or wrongness of a human action. In other words, ethics undertakes the systematic study (that is, questioning and critical examination) of the underlying principles of morality. Hence, it is interested primarily in the illustration of a more general problem and the examination of underlying assumptions and the critical evaluation of moral principles.

Morality, on the other hand, is more prescriptive in nature. It tells us what we ought to do and exhorts us to follow the right way. According to Terrance McConnell (1994), "morality is characterized as an 'end-governed rational enterprise' whose object is to equip people with a body of norms (rules and values) that make for peaceful and collectively satisfying coexistence by facilitating their living together and interacting in a way that is productive for the realization of the general benefit". For example, a religious leader may ask her followers to be good at all times. In this way, a moralist may want to keep alive the values she considers to be worthwhile and to improve the moral quality of the community where she belongs. Hence, morality, at the very least, aims to guide one's action by reason and gives equal weight to the interests of each individual affected by one's decision. Indeed, this gives us a picture of what it really means to be a morally upright person.

As we can see, the terms ethics and morality can be used interchangeably. However, there is a fine line that divides the two. In other words, we can distinguish one from the other in some respects.

The first idea that came to our mind when we ask the difference between morality and ethics is that the latter generally refers to the systematic study of the rightness and wrongness of a human action, while the former is generally understood as the rightness or wrongness of a human action. In this way, we can say that **ethics** is the specific branch of philosophy that studies the **morality** (that is, the rightness or wrongness) of a human act. With this, we may initially conclude that ethics is the science of "morals", while morality is the practice of ethics.

Based on the above initial discussion on the difference between the two terms, we can now draw the idea that ethics attempts to provide systems of moral principles and the reasons why these principles are valid. Hence, ethics is more concerned with theories that can be used to explain why a particular moral principle is valid or not, right or wrong. It is for this reason that ethicists have come up

with some of the **basic ethical principles** that may help determine the rightness or wrongness of a human action. Some of these basic ethical principles are: 1) Respect for persons, 2) Truthfulness and Confidentiality, 3) Autonomy and Informed Consent, 4) Beneficence, 5) Non-maleficence, and 6) Justice.

Now, as already mentioned, **morality** refers to principles of right and wrong behavior or rightness and wrongness (that is, goodness and badness) of human actions. **And more importantly**, in determining the rightness or wrongness of human actions, the moral agent is guided by the broader rules or principles of ethics. For instance, the person's moral belief that killing is wrong may stem from the basic ethical principle of "Respect for persons" or "Non-maleficence". Indeed, this example further explains the basic difference between ethics and morals: if **ethics** says that killing is wrong because it violates the basic ethical principles of "Respect for persons" or "Non-maleficence", **morality**, on the other hand, says "Do not kill" because it is wrong. Again, this is the reason why ethics is understood as the science of morals, while morality is the practice of (the basic principles of) ethics.

Types of Ethics

During the mid-20th century, according to Sumner (1967), a "certain theory in the methodology of ethics has gradually become more and more widely accepted, at least by British and American moral philosophers". According to this position, there are two ways of doing ethical inquiry, namely, **normative ethics** and **meta-ethics**.

On the one hand, **normative ethics** is prescriptive in nature as it seeks to set norms or standards that regulate right and wrong or good and bad conduct. This may involve articulating the good habits that we should acquire, the duties that we should follow, or the consequences of our behavior on others. Hence, normative ethics normally attempts to develop guidelines or theories that tell us how we ought to behave. For example, Immanuel Kant's claim that an act is morally right if it is done for the sake of duty is an example of a normative ethics.

Meta-ethics, on the other hand, is descriptive in nature. According to Sumner (1967), "metaethics is allegedly constituted, at least in part, by questions of the meanings of the various ethical terms and functions of ethical utterances." Hence, if a normative ethical inquiry is evaluative and prescriptive, metaethics is analytical and descriptive. Put simply, metaethics is a type of ethical inquiry

that aims to understand the nature and dynamics of ethical principles. It asks questions about the nature and origin of moral facts, as well as the way in which we learn and acquire moral beliefs. Thus, for example, if normative ethics urges us to do good at all times, metaethics asks the question "What is good?". For sure, if a moral philosopher attempts to address the questions "What is good?", "What is justice?", "Why should I be moral?", then that moral philosopher is doing metaethics. Hence, when Plato proposed an answer to the question "Why should I be moral", Plato was doing metaethics—indeed, Plato raised a metaethical question.

In the course of the development of ethics, **applied ethics** became its third major type. As its name suggests, applied ethics is the actual application of ethical or moral theories for the purpose of deciding which ethical or moral actions are appropriate in a given situation. For this reason, casuists (that is, the adherents of applied ethics) are concerned with individual moral problems, such as abortion or euthanasia, and attempt to resolve the conflicting issues that surround these particular moral problems. Casuists may also act on some occasions in an advisory capacity, such as guiding individuals in their choice of actions. For example, they may attempt to resolve the conflicting duties of a mother suffering from ectopic pregnancy who has no other option than to abort the fetus.

Applied ethics is usually divided into different fields. For example, we may talk about **business ethics**, which deals with ethical behavior in the corporate world; **biomedical** and **environmental ethics**, which deal with issues relating to health, welfare, and the responsibility we have towards people and our environment; and **social ethics**, which deals with the principles and guidelines that regulate corporate welfare within societies.

Finally, the difference between the three major types of ethics can be illustrated in the following situation:

A police officer shoots a terrorist who is about to blow up a crowded shopping mall.

The act of the police officer is morally wrong according to **metaethics** because it is always wrong to kill. As is well known, killing in itself is intrinsically wrong. However, if the police officer does not shoot the terrorist, many innocent people will die or get injured. Though the police officer's act may be wrong, the adherents of **normative ethics** may say that it is the right thing to do in this particular situation

because not doing so will result in the death of so many people. Hence, the action might be morally correct. Finally, the **casuists** may say that the police officer is just doing his best to fulfill his duty, that is, to protect as many innocent lives as possible.

Things to Do:

1. Create a summary of the definition of ethics and morals (compare and contrast the two terms), this will help you to better understand and remember the meaning of the terms. (6 pts.)
2. Give three situations or examples to better illustrate each type of ethics. (9 pts.)

LESSON 2. Rules and Moral Standards

Rules and Its Importance

Rules refer to a set of guidelines which have been put in place in different countries and communities and been accepted by all. Rules are useful tools in guiding and monitoring the interactions of humans in our society. A rule is a prescribed guide for conduct or action. Rules help guide actions toward desired results.

When used appropriately, rules provide a sense of predictability and consistency for people, thereby promoting physical, moral, social, and emotional safety. At the heart of ethics is a concern about something or someone other than ourselves and our own desires and self-interest.

The following are the usual rules we encounter in our lives:

- Etiquette – standards by which manners are judged to be good or bad normally dictated by a socio-economic elite.
- Athletic or Sports Rules – standards by which we judge how good or bad a game is played, usually formulated by governing bodies.
- Statutes – standards by which legal right or wrong is judged in a democracy, formulated by representatives of people.

- Language – standards by which grammatically right or wrong language is judged, evolving through its usage.
- Aesthetics – standards by which good or bad art is judged dictated by a small circle of art specialists.

Rules are specific sets of norms of behavior, regulations, and laws established on purpose to regulate the life in the community. These norms secure the order and allow providing total chaos. The sets of rules available nowadays have undergone a long formation process. There were many variations and transformations applied. Due to that, we now have well-established social, governmental and educational mechanisms that work as a clock, accurately, simultaneously and in organized way. The availability of rules is a crucial criterion allowing to call society civilized and well developed.

Importance of Rules

Rules help people in many aspects of life. They enable people to organize all the processes correctly, starting from home chores and ending with more complicated issues as the functioning of as whole country. Rules are specific modes of behavior that secure a regulated flow of all processes.

Rules are important because they tend to protect the weaker class in the society as they might be in disadvantageous position if rules are broken. When rules are used in the right way, they provide a stable environment and human co-existence in a society which leads to peace and development. The process of setting rules aims to craft rules in line with some desired results. For example, rules in schools and other institutions promote trust, fairness and discipline in a bid to establish desirable relationship among students and people.

Besides, rules are vital in one's life because peace and order are maintained, an important ingredient for society's development. As a way of maintaining these rules, many societies have adopted and change them into law. These assure that no rules will be broken. If one violates the rule, a corresponding punishment is imposed.

Most of us are basically honest, and knowing the rules means that we usually try to follow them. One reason we do is to avoid punishment, but the stronger argument for following the rules is to make the world peaceful and fair.

Moral Standards versus Non-moral Ones – Why the need to distinguish moral standards from non-moral ones?

It is important to note that different societies have different moral beliefs and that our beliefs are deeply influenced by our own culture and context. For this reason, some values do have moral implications, while others don't. Let us consider, for example, the wearing of hijab. For sure, in traditional Muslim communities, the wearing of hijab is the most appropriate act that women have to do in terms of dressing up. In fact, for some Muslims, showing parts of the woman's body, such as the face and legs, is despicable. However, in many parts of the world, especially in Western societies, most people don't mind if women barely cover their bodies. As a matter of fact, the Hollywood canon of beauty glorifies a sexy and slim body and the wearing of extremely daring dress. The point here is that people in the West may have pitied the Muslim women who wear hijab, while some Muslims may find women who dress up daringly despicable.

Again, this clearly shows that different cultures have different moral standards. What is a matter of moral indifference, that is, a matter of taste (hence, non-moral value) in one culture may be a matter of moral significance in another.

Now, the danger here is that one culture may impose its own cultural standard on others, which may result in a clash in cultural values and beliefs. When this happens, as we may already know, violence and crime may ensue, such as religious violence and ethnic cleansing.

How can we address this cultural conundrum?

This is where the importance of understanding the difference between moral standards (that is, of what is a moral issue) and non-moral ones (that is, of what is a non-moral issue—thus, a matter of taste) comes in. This issue may be too obvious and insignificant for some people, but understanding the difference between the two may have far-reaching implications. For one, once we have distinguished

moral standards from non-moral ones, of course, through the aid of the principles and theories in ethics, we will be able to identify fundamental ethical values that may guide our actions. Indeed, once we know that particular values and beliefs are non-moral, we will be able to avoid running the risk of falling into the pit of cultural reductionism (that is, taking complex cultural issues as simple and homogenous ones) and the unnecessary imposition of one's own cultural standard on others. The point here is that if such standards are non-moral (that is, a matter of taste), then we don't have the right to impose them on others. But if such standards are moral ones, such as not killing or harming people, then we may have the right to force others to act accordingly. In this way, we may be able to find a common moral ground, such as agreeing not to steal, lie, cheat, kill, harm, and deceive our fellow human beings.

Now, what are moral standards, and how do they differ from non-moral ones?

Moral Standards and their Characteristics

Moral standards are norms that individuals or groups have about the kinds of actions believed to be morally right or wrong, as well as the values placed on what we believed to be morally good or morally bad. Moral standards normally promote "the good", that is, the welfare and well-being of humans as well as animals and the environment. Moral standards, therefore, prescribe what humans ought to do in terms of rights and obligations.

According to some scholars, moral standards are the sum of combined norms and values. In other words, norms plus values equal moral standards. On the one hand, norms are understood as general rules about our actions or behaviors. For example, we may say "We are always under the obligation to fulfill our promises" or "It is always believed that killing innocent people is absolutely wrong". On the other hand, values are understood as enduring beliefs or statements about what is good and desirable or not. For example, we may say "Helping the poor is good" or "Cheating during exams is bad".

According to many scholars, moral standards have the following characteristics, namely:

1) moral standards deal with matters we think can seriously injure or benefit humans, animals, and the environment, such as child abuse, rape, and murder;

2) moral standards are not established or changed by the decisions of authoritative individuals or bodies. Indeed, moral standards rest on the adequacy of the reasons that are taken to support and justify them. For sure, we don't need a law to back up our moral conviction that killing innocent people is absolutely wrong;
3) moral standards are overriding, that is, they take precedence over other standards and considerations, especially of self-interest;
4) moral standards are based on impartial considerations. Hence, moral standards are fair and just;
5) moral standards are associated with special emotions (such as guilt and shame) and vocabulary (such as right, wrong, good, and bad).

Non-moral Standards

Non-moral standards refer to standards by which we judge what is good or bad and right or wrong in a non-moral way. Examples of non-moral standards are standards of etiquette by which we judge manners as good or bad, standards we call the law by which we judge something as legal or illegal, and standards of aesthetics by which we judge art as good or rubbish. Hence, we should not confuse morality with etiquette, statutes (law), aesthetics, and even with religion.

As we can see, non-moral standards are matters of taste or preference. Hence, a scrupulous observance of these types of standards does not make one a moral person. Violation of said standards also does not pose any threat to human well-being.

Finally, as a way of distinguishing moral standards from non-moral ones, if a moral standard says "Do not harm innocent people" or "Don't steal", a non-moral standard says "Don't text while driving" or "Don't talk while the mouth is full".

Things to Do:

1. List ten (10) house rules that are imposed to you by your parents and rank them according to what is important for you. Explain your ranking.
2. Give examples of moral standards (5) and non-moral standards (5) that you usually encounter in your everyday life.